present or emerging around the 16th century: Zoroastrianism, Jainism, Sikhism and Pushtimargi Vaishnavism. All four belief systems were vital in dispelling conservative notions about trade and overseas travel. Interaction with people and exposure to these ideas led to a much greater acceptance of trading as a legitimate activity and migration as a means of expanding business and securing a livelihood. Merchants affiliated with these schools of thought generously paid back to construct shrines and places of worship, which in turn legitimized their way of life. In some of the coastal tracts, Muslim merchants were also free from taboos on travel. In Chettinad, closer to the coast, it would appear that a long history of regional trading connections between Tamil Nadu and South East Asia had dented notions about the loss of caste upon travelling overseas. Social acceptance of trade and travel is thus important to explain the geographical selectivity of merchant migrations in India before the 20th century. These migrations were also directed towards regions that were demographically marked by an absence or low share of trading castes in the Gangetic heartland and the Deccan. They filled the void in many places as the Mughal Empire began to fall apart in the 18th century and they grew under British protection in the 19th century. By then, Calcutta and Bombay had come up as major attractions thanks to commercial opportunities and the provision of a modern legal system that resolved cross-community disputes, thereby facilitating greater trade.[89]

For migrant merchants, social acceptance was important within their respective communities even if it was not prevalent in the regions that they migrated to. The migration of capital was often related to the opium and slave trades. When ethical attitudes to these trades changed, the merchants were slow to shift away from their lucrative practices. Migrant traders, financiers, entrepreneurs and moneylenders would also cause suspicion because of their capacity to generate wealth. The Chettiars in Burma, Marwaris in north Maharashtra, Gujaratis in East Africa and Punjabis in Russia, or for that matter the Baghdadi Jews and Scots in India, all benefited from state protection initially but were affected by local